

Prophecy Fallible Vs Binding

prc-prophecy-fallible-vs-binding

Spiritual Gifts · Prophecy · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

DISPUTED

score 0.975
confidence medium

Statement under examination

Any modern claim to prophecy must be tested by Scripture and is never binding on conscience the way Scripture is. New revelation that adds to or contradicts Scripture is rejected.

In plain language

This proposition makes three claims: that modern prophecy must be tested by Scripture, that it is never binding the way Scripture is, and that revelation adding to or contradicting Scripture is rejected. The original-language evidence cleanly supports the first and third. The verb dokimazete, test, is used in First Thessalonians five and First John four for testing utterances and spirits, and in First Corinthians fourteen the verb diakrinetosan, let the others weigh, commands the same sifting of prophetic speech. Revelation twenty-two forbids both adding (epititheimi) and taking away (aphaireo) from the words of the prophecy of the book, fixing the word as closed. Second Timothy three calls all Scripture God-breathed, theopneustos, and sufficient to equip the man of God. So the testing claim and the no-addition claim rest on firm lexical ground. The middle claim is where the words stop short of a single answer. Two facts in the text drive the dispute. First, the noun propheteia and the agent noun prophetes are the same lemmas used for Isaiah, for the writing prophets of the Apocalypse, for the foundation prophets of Ephesians two, and for the congregational prophets weighed in First Corinthians fourteen. The canon supplies no built-in vocabulary that ranks one of these as binding and another as graded. Second, Agabus in Acts twenty-one is called prophetes and predicts that the Jews will bind Paul and deliver him to the gentiles, but in the same chapter the Romans not the Jews do the binding, with Roman chains. The verb of binding matches; the agent does not strictly match. Some readers take this lexical near-miss as evidence that genuine New Testament prophecy could be true in substance without meeting the binary Deuteronomy eighteen fulfillment standard. Other readers take it as a reason to confine genuine binding prophecy to a closed apostolic-era category. The words themselves do not rank these two readings. The verdict is therefore disputed: two of the three claims are lexically secure, while the comparative claim about how binding retained prophecy is depends on a reading the words permit but do not compel.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H1697	דָּבָר	dabar	word	1,454
H2087	זָדוֹן	zadon	arrogance	11
H3045	יָדָע	yada	to know	
H3808	לֹא	lo	not	
H5030	נָבִיא	nabi	prophet	305
G0254	ἅλυσις	halusis	chain	
G0601	ἀποκαλύπτω	apokaluptō	to reveal	
G0739	ἄρτιος	artios	competent	

G0851	ἀφαιρέω	aphaireo	to remove	10
G1124	γραφή	graphe	a writing	51
G1210	δέω	deo	to bind	43
G1252	διακρίνω	diakrino	to judge/doubt	19
G1319	διδασκαλία	didaskalia	teaching	
G1381	δοκιμάζω	dokimazo	to test	22
G1484	ἔθνος	ethnos	Gentiles	
G1785	ἐντολή	entolē	commandment	
G1822	ἐξαρτίζω	exartizō	to finish/furnish	
G1848	ἐξουθενέω	exoutheneo	to reject	11
G1882	ἐπανόρθωσις	epanorthosis	correcting	1
G1949	ἐπιλαμβάνομαι	epilambanō	to catch	
G2007	ἐπιτίθημι	epitithemi	to put/lay on	39
G2310	θεμέλιος	themelios	foundation	
G2453	Ἰουδαῖος	Ioudaios	Jew	
G3056	λόγος	logos	word	339
G3860	παραδίδωμι	paradidomi	to deliver	119
G3956	πᾶς	pas	all	
G4394	προφητεία	propheteia	prophecy	19
G4396	προφήτης	prophetes	prophet	149

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The lexical pattern cleanly supports two of the proposition's three claims and leaves the middle claim genuinely contested. Testing is commanded with explicit verbs: dokimazete (1 Thess 5:21), dokimazete ta pneumata (1 John 4:1), and diakrinetosan let the others weigh (1 Cor 14:29). Closure of the prophetic book is also explicit (epitithemi and aphaireo in Rev 22:18-19). The middle claim, that any retained modern prophecy is never binding the way Scripture is, is materially contested because the same noun propheteia (G4394) and the same agent noun prophetes (G4396) are used univocally for OT prophets, NT writing prophets, and NT congregational prophets (1 Cor 14:29, 32, 37; Eph 2:20; Eph 3:5; Acts 21:10), and the Agabus oracle (Acts 21:11) names binders the words do not perfectly match in the outcome (Acts 21:33), so the canon supplies two patterns the words do not rank: a binary OT prophet test (Deut 18:22) and a graded NT sift-and-hold instruction. Therefore disputed.

Scripture

1Thess.5.20 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4394 προφητεία, G1848 ἐξουθενέω

Force. The clause propheteias me exoutheneite (do not despise prophecies) treats prophetic utterance as a category not to be discarded wholesale, presupposing speech that has continuing value and must be received before it is weighed. The noun propheteia is the same lemma used for the words of the book of Revelation (Rev 22:18-19) and for the prophetic Scripture of 2 Pet 1:20-21.

1Thess.5.21 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1381 δοκιμάζω, G3956 πᾶς

Force. panta de dokimazete, to kalon katechete (test all things, hold fast the good) commands an assaying of every utterance and selective retention of the good. The verb dokimazo (G1381) denotes proving or assaying metal and is used twenty-two times in the NT, including 1 John 4:1 (dokimazete ta pneumata), Rom 12:2, and Eph 5:10. It entails a sift in which some content is kept and the rest released. This supports the testing claim but presents a gradated model rather than a binary accept or execute model.

1Cor.14.29 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4396 προφήτης, G1252 διακρίνω

Force. prophetai de duo e treis laleitosan, kai hoi alloi diakrinetosan (let two or three prophets speak, and let the others weigh, distinguish). The verb diakrino (G1252) means to judge between, distinguish, evaluate, and is used nineteen times in the NT for discerning food (Acts 11:12), discerning the body (1 Cor 11:29), and self-examination. The imperative directs the congregation to weigh prophetic utterance piece by piece, the same gradated sift posture as 1 Thess 5:21.

1Cor.14.37 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4396 προφήτης, G1785 ἐντολή

Force. ei tis dokei prophetes einai e pneumatikos, epiginosketo ha grapho hymin hoti kyriou estin entole (if anyone thinks he is a prophet or spiritual, let him recognize that what I write to you is the Lord's command). Paul applies prophetes (G4396) to the same congregational figures of 14:29 and then asserts that his own written word is kyriou entole, which lexically subordinates congregational propheteia to apostolic graphe within the same chapter, supplying a real datum for an authority gradient.

1John.4.1 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1381 δοκιμάζω, G4396 προφήτης

Force. me panti pneumatī pisteuete, alla dokimazete ta pneumata ei ek tou theou estin, hoti polloi pseudoprophetai exelelythasin eis ton kosmon (do not believe every spirit, but test the spirits whether they are from God, because many false prophets have gone out into the world). The imperative dokimazete is the same verb as 1 Thess 5:21, applied to spirits and to pseudoprophetai (false prophets), confirming that the testing posture is canon-wide and that spurious prophetic claims are an expected hazard.

Deut.18.20 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H5030 נביא, H2087 ידון

Force. The prophet (nabi, H5030) who speaks a word in YHWH's name that He did not command, or who speaks in the name of other gods, must die. ETCBC clause-function tags here mark Pred, Cmpl, and Nega patterns characteristic of legal apodosis. The death sentence makes the standard for a claimed prophet absolute, not gradated, with no surviving partial authority.

Deut.18.21 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H1697 דבר, H3045 ידע

Force. The clause eka neda et hadabar asher lo dibbero YHWH (how shall we know the word that the LORD has not spoken) frames the chapter as supplying a test of authenticity, a recognition that not every claim to a divine word is genuine.

Deut.18.22 · **for** · genre: law

Key terms. H1697 דבר; H3808 לא

Force. lo yihyeh hadabar velo yavo (the word does not happen and does not come to pass) is the fulfillment test: a word that fails verification was not from YHWH and the speaker is not to be feared. The standard is non-fulfillment equals false, a binary verdict with no surviving partial authority. This is the OT prophet test cited at Deut 13:1-5 and reapplied in Jer 28 and Ezek 13.

Acts.21.11 · **complicates** · genre: narrative

Key terms. G4396 προφήτης, G1210 δέω, G3860 παραδίδωμι

Force. Agabus, called prophetes (G4396) in v.10, says houtos ton andra hou estin he zone haute houtos desousin (G1210 deo) en Ierousalem hoi Ioudaioi (G2453, the Jews) kai paradosousin (G3860 paradidomi) eis cheiras ethnon (into the hands of gentiles). The verb deo (bind) and the action paradidomi (deliver) are anchored to the Jews as agent of binding and to delivery to gentiles as a separate act.

Acts.21.33 · **complicates** · genre: narrative

Key terms. G1949 ἐπιλαμβάνομαι, G1210 δέω, G0254 ἄλυσις

Force. The chiliarch epelabeto autou (G1949, took hold of him) kai ekeleusen (G2753 keleuo, commanded) dethenai (G1210 deo, to be bound) halysesi (G0254, with chains) dysi. The binder is the Roman commander not the Jews, and the binding is by Roman chains. The verb deo matches Agabus' verb but the agent does not match hoi Ioudaioi of v.11. This is a real lexical near-miss that the schema must record honestly: the prediction is largely fulfilled but not precisely, which weighs against Agabus' utterance meeting the binary Deut 18:22 fulfillment standard while still being treated by Luke as a true prophetic warning.

Eph.2.20 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4396 προφήτης, G2310 θεμέλιος

Force. epikodomethentes epi to themelio ton apostolon kai propheton (built on the foundation of the apostles and prophets). The genitive ton propheton uses G4396 (the same lemma as Acts 21:10 of Agabus and 1 Cor 14:29 of congregational prophets) coordinated with apostolon, placing some class of NT prophets at the church's foundation. Whether this refers to OT prophets, NT writing prophets, or includes the same congregational figures of 1 Cor 14 is contested by the words alone.

Eph.3.5 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4396 προφήτης, G0601 ἀποκαλύπτω

Force. nyn apekalyphthe tois hagiois apostolois autou kai prophetais en pneumati (now revealed to His holy apostles and prophets in the Spirit). The adverb nyn (now) and the coordination with apostolois locate these prophetai (G4396) in the new-covenant era, but the lexeme does not by itself rank their utterances relative to apostolic graphe.

Rev.22.18 · **for** · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G2007 ἐπιτίθημι, G4394 προφητεία

Force. ean tis epithei ep auta (if anyone adds to them) attaches a curse of plagues to adding to tous logous tes propheteias tou bibliou toutou (the words of the prophecy of this book). The prohibition is against augmenting the fixed prophetic word and uses the same lemma propheteia (G4394) used in 1 Thess 5:20 and 1 Cor 13:2.

Rev.22.19 · **for** · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G0851 ἀφαιρέω, G3056 λόγος

Force. kai ean tis aphelei apo ton logon (and if anyone takes away from the words) threatens removal from the tree of life and the holy city for subtracting from the prophetic words of the book. Adding and subtracting are both forbidden, fixing the word as closed and non-augmentable.

2Tim.3.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1124 γραφή, G1319 διδασκαλία

Force. pasa graphe theopneustos (all Scripture is God-breathed) and useful pros didaskalian, pros elegmon, pros epanorthosin (for teaching, reproof, correction). theopneustos predicates a unique divine origin of graphe, which establishes Scripture as the norming standard against which other claims are measured.

2Tim.3.17 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0739 ἄρτιος, G1822 ἐξαρτίζω

Force. hina artios e ho tou theou anthropos, pros pan ergon agathon exertismenos (that the man of God may be complete, fully equipped for every good work). artios (a NT hapax) and exertismenos assert sufficiency of Scripture for the equipping it describes, but the clause is purposive and does not by itself pronounce on whether other revelatory speech could coexist as non-norming.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
1Thess.5.21	Isa.8.20	tsk	1
1Thess.5.21	1John.4.1	openbible	1
Deut.18.20	Deut.13.1	tsk	1
Deut.18.22	Deut.13.2	tsk	1
Deut.18.22	Jer.28.9	tsk	1
Deut.18.22	Isa.41.22	tsk	1
Deut.18.22	Prov.26.2	tsk	1
Rev.22.18	Deut.4.2	tsk	1
Rev.22.18	Prov.30.6	tsk	1
2Tim.3.16	Ps.19.7	tsk	1
2Tim.3.16	2Sam.23.2	tsk	1
2Tim.3.17	2Tim.2.21	tsk	1
Acts.21.11	Acts.21.33	openbible	1
Eph.2.20	Eph.3.5	tsk	1

Complicating texts

1Cor.14.30 · addressed

The provision that a seated prophet yield when an apokalypsis comes to another (ean de allo apokalypthe kathemeno) assumes ongoing congregational revelatory speech in the apostolic assembly. The noun apokalypsis (G0602) is the same word used for the revelation of Jesus Christ in Rev 1:1 and Gal 1:12. The lexeme does not by itself rank such apokalypsis relative to apostolic graphe, so its existence does not settle the bindingness question but does establish that ongoing revelatory speech was a normal apostolic-era category.

Acts.21.4 · addressed

Disciples at Tyre tell Paul dia tou pneumatatos (through the Spirit) not to step on (epibainein) Jerusalem, yet Paul proceeds and Luke does not treat him as disobedient. The construction is a Spirit-prompted utterance directed against an apostolic itinerary that the apostle nevertheless overrides. Lexically this records a category of Spirit-mediated speech that did not function as absolutely binding even on its own apostolic hearer, which is a real datum on the disputed side of the bindingness question.

Acts.21.10 · addressed

Agabus is named prophetes (G4396), the same lemma as OT prophets and as the congregational prophets of 1 Cor 14. The shared lexeme is the lexical source of the dispute: if the same word names both Isaiah and Agabus and the 1 Cor 14 weighers, the canon supplies no built-in vocabulary distinction between binding revelatory prophecy and gradated congregational prophecy.

Acts.21.11 · addressed

Agabus predicts that hoi loudaioi (the Jews) will bind (deo) Paul and deliver (paradidomi) him to the gentiles. In Acts 21:33 the Roman chiliarch is the one who orders the binding with chains (halyseis), and the Jews are the mob attempting to kill him. The predicted verb deo is fulfilled; the predicted agent (the Jews) does not strictly match the actual agent (the Romans). On the binary Deut 18:22 standard this would be a problematic inexactness; yet Luke clearly presents Agabus as a true prophet. This is the principal lexical datum that some readers cite for a category of true but not infallibly precise prophecy.

1Cor.14.32 · addressed

pneumata propheton prophetais hypotassetai (the spirits of prophets are subject to prophets). The verb hypotasso (G5293) under a copula construction asserts that prophetic spirits are under the control of prophets, presupposing that congregational prophetic utterance is not an overwhelming irresistible word but a controllable, weighable speech. This argues for the gradated NT model but does not by itself foreclose a binding category.

Eph.2.20 · unaddressed

Foundational prophetai (G4396) coordinated with apostoloi at the church's foundation. Whether this names OT prophets, a distinct class of NT writing prophets, or the same congregational figures of 1 Cor 14 is not settled by the lexeme alone. The unresolved referent is itself part of why the bindingness comparison is disputed at the lexical level.

Concordance traversed

G1381, G1252, G4394, G4396, G1848, H5030, H1697, H2087, G2007, G0851, G1124, G3056, G1882, G0739, G1822, G1210, G3860, G2453, G1484

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

Rev 22:18-19 carries apparatus marks in the bundle surface (the diple symbols on epithesei and aphelei reflect editorial variation between aphele and aphelei), but the lexical verdict does not turn on these readings. The addition or subtraction prohibition stands across the variant forms. NT passages outside 3 John are in ECM shadow status.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. cessationism, continuationism, fallible_prophecy, office_prophecy_only

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

cessationism: affirms · Reads 2 Tim 3:16-17 sufficiency (theopneustos graphe, artios, exertismenos) and Rev 22:18-19 closure (epitithemi and aphaireo on the words of the prophecy) as terminating revelatory prophecy with the close of the apostolic period, so any modern claim is by definition non-binding and to be rejected if it adds to Scripture. On this reading 1 Thess 5:21 and 1 Cor 14:29 belong to a transitional apostolic-era practice now ceased.

continuationism with fallible prophecy: disputed · Reads 1 Thess 5:20-21 (dokimazete), 1 Cor 14:29 (diakrinetosan), 1 John 4:1 (dokimazete ta pneumata), and 1 Cor 14:30-32 (hypotassetai, apokalypsis) as instituting an ongoing sift-and-retain prophecy distinct in authority from apostolic graphe. The Agabus near-miss (Acts 21:11 vs 21:33) and the Acts 21:4 override are read as lexical evidence that NT congregational prophecy could be genuine yet not infallibly precise. On this lens the testing and no-addition claims hold, but the absolute

never-binding claim requires qualification because retained good is to be held fast (katechete).

office prophecy with binding equivalence: affirms_with_caveat · Reads the noun prophetes (G4396) as carrying a single binding sense across canon, so that Agabus, the 1 Cor 14 prophets, the Eph 2:20 foundation prophets, and OT nabi all stand under the same Deut 18:22 standard. On this reading, genuine prophecy that survives the test is by definition binding, but it is also by definition rare and tested. The proposition is affirmed but its third clause is read as redundant once any non-genuine word is sifted out.

old testament prophet standard applied univocally: affirms · Reads Deut 18:20-22 as the controlling test for any prophetic claim: non-fulfillment equals false, with no surviving partial authority. Applied univocally to modern claims this affirms the proposition. Its univocal transfer to NT congregational prophecy is itself the disputed step, since the NT lexemes (dokimazo, diakrino) describe a gradated rather than binary process.

The verdict turns on whether the OT binary prophet test (Deut 18) and the NT sift-and-hold instruction (1 Thess 5:21, 1 Cor 14:29, 1 John 4:1) describe one standard or two distinct orders of prophecy. The anchor lexemes establish that testing is commanded and that the canonical prophetic word may not be augmented, but they do not by themselves resolve the relative authority question. The same lemmas propheteia and prophetes are used univocally for OT and NT prophets, which is a real lexical pressure on the proposition's middle claim. progressive_revelation is set true because the relationship between OT and NT prophetic categories is itself part of the dispute.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Modern claims to prophecy are to be evaluated against Scripture. The question is whether any such claim, once evaluated, carries an authority equal to, lesser than, or other than the written Scripture, and whether revelation that adds to or contradicts Scripture is to be received.

The phrase binding on conscience the way Scripture is embeds a comparative norming claim (Scripture as the final conscience-binding standard) that is the contested matter, not a neutral premise. The clause new revelation that adds to or contradicts Scripture is rejected also presupposes a closed-canon conclusion. The testing and no-addition portions are lexically supported. The verdict is derived on the original stem and lands as disputed because of the comparative bindingness claim and because propheteia and prophetes are univocal lexemes across canon.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Thess.5.21
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.14.29
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.14.37
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1John.4.1
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Acts.21.11
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Acts.21.33
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.2.20
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1381
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1252
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4394
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4396
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2007
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0851

lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1210
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H5030
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Deut.18.22
syntax	ETCBC-BHSA	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Deut.18.20
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Deut.18.22
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Acts.21.11

License audit

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Flags

lexically-disputed · ecm-shadow · complicating-unresolved